

1. What is the Diffusion of Innovations Framework?

The framework, associated with **Everett Rogers**, divides adopters into five groups:

1. **Innovators – 2.5%**
2. **Early Adopters – 13.5%**
3. **Early Majority – 34%**
4. **Late Majority – 34%**
5. **Laggards – 16%**

Together they represent **100% of the potential adoption population**.

A simple way to understand the curve is:

Experiment → Influence → Validate → Mainstream → Traditional

The same technology can therefore be viewed very differently by different groups.

2. Innovators – 2.5%

Who are they?

Innovators are the people who are willing to experiment with new technologies even when the technology is:

- expensive
- unproven
- complicated
- risky
- not widely adopted

They enjoy experimenting and are comfortable with uncertainty.

Example: Generative AI

When generative AI tools first became available, some technology enthusiasts immediately experimented with them.

They might have asked:

"Can I use AI to generate software code?"

"Can AI create marketing content?"

"Can AI analyse business data?"

They did not necessarily wait for hundreds of companies to prove the technology first.

Business example

A company might be one of the first organisations to experiment with **AI-powered customer service**.

The company might deploy an experimental chatbot even though:

- competitors are not using it
- ROI is uncertain
- customers may not immediately accept it

The goal is to learn.

What motivates innovators?

Curiosity + experimentation + willingness to take risks

Typical question

"What can this new technology do?"

3. Early Adopters – 13.5% 🌟

Who are they?

Early adopters are different from innovators.

They may not want to experiment simply for experimentation's sake. Instead, they see a **strategic opportunity**.

They ask:

"Can this technology give my organisation an advantage?"

They are often influential because other people look to them for guidance.

Real-world example: AI in business

Suppose AI-powered predictive analytics is still relatively new.

An early-adopter company might say:

"Our competitors are not using predictive analytics yet. If we implement it successfully, we could improve inventory planning."

The company conducts a controlled implementation.

It discovers:

Inventory forecasting accuracy improved.

The company then shares its results internally and potentially becomes a reference point for others.

Typical question

"How can this technology give us a strategic advantage?"

4. The Chasm

This is one of the most important concepts in the diagram.

The **chasm** represents the difficult transition between:

Early Adopters → Early Majority

Why is this difficult?

Because these two groups have different expectations.

Early adopters

They may say:

"This technology is innovative. Let's experiment."

Early majority

They may say:

"Show me that it works."

The early majority generally wants:

- proven results
- reliable technology
- clear ROI
- case studies
- references
- support
- predictable implementation

- manageable risk

Therefore, a technology can be **exciting to early adopters but still fail to become mainstream.**

5. Real-World Example of the Chasm

Imagine a company develops an AI system that predicts equipment failures.

Early adopters may say:

"This is impressive. Let's test it."

The company runs several pilot projects.

However, the early majority asks:

"How much will it cost?"

"What is the ROI?"

"Does it integrate with our existing system?"

"Can our employees use it?"

"What happens if the AI makes an incorrect prediction?"

"Which other companies have successfully implemented it?"

If the technology provider cannot answer these questions, adoption may stop.

This is the **chasm**.

To cross the chasm

The technology provider needs to move from:

"Look at our innovative technology!"

to:

"Here is a proven business solution with measurable results."

6. Early Majority – 34% 🇮🇹

Who are they?

The **Early Majority** are practical adopters.

They are interested in innovation, but they don't normally want to be the first organisation to take a major risk.

They want evidence.

Their thinking is:

"If this has been proven to work, we can consider adopting it."

What do they look for?

- ROI
- case studies
- customer reviews
- proven results
- technical support
- implementation plans
- integration with existing systems
- reasonable cost

Real-world example: Cloud Computing

A company might initially continue using its own physical servers.

After seeing other companies successfully move to cloud platforms, management begins evaluating cloud migration.

They may ask:

"How much can we save?"

"How secure is the cloud?"

"Can we migrate our existing applications?"

"What companies in our industry are already using it?"

Once there is enough evidence, the company adopts cloud computing.

Typical question

"Does it work, and is it worth the investment?"

7. Late Majority – 34% 🚗

Who are they?

The **Late Majority** are more cautious.

They often adopt a technology because it has become:

- widely accepted
- industry standard
- expected by customers
- expected by business partners
- difficult to avoid

They may not personally be excited about the technology.

Example: Contactless payments

When contactless payment technology became widespread, many businesses adopted it because customers increasingly expected to pay using:

- contactless cards
- mobile wallets
- NFC-enabled devices

A late-majority business might think:

"Most customers are already using contactless payment. We need to support it."

Rather than:

"This is an exciting new technology!"

Typical question

"Has this become the normal way of doing business?"

8. Laggards – 16% 🏠

Who are they?

Laggards are the last group to adopt an innovation.

They tend to prefer:

- familiar systems

- established processes
- traditional methods
- low-risk solutions

They may continue using an old technology until there is a strong reason to change.

Example

Imagine a small business still using:

Paper invoices + manual filing

while most competitors have already adopted cloud accounting software.

The owner might say:

"Our current system works. Why should we change?"

Eventually, the business may adopt cloud accounting because:

- suppliers require electronic invoices
- customers expect digital invoices
- paper records become inefficient
- the old system is no longer supported

Typical question

"Why should we change something that already works?"

9. One Technology Through the Entire Rogers Curve

Let's use **Generative AI** as an example.

Adoption Group	Example behaviour
 Innovators – 2.5%	Experiment with AI immediately
 Early Adopters – 13.5%	Use AI strategically to gain an advantage
 Early Majority – 34%	Adopt after seeing ROI and successful case studies
 Late Majority – 34%	Adopt because AI has become widely used

Adoption Group	Example behaviour
 Laggards – 16%	Continue using traditional methods until adoption becomes necessary

Notice that **the technology does not change**.

What changes is the **attitude of the adopter**.

10. Another Example: Electric Vehicles

Consider the adoption of electric vehicles.

Innovators

Some consumers buy early EV models despite:

- limited charging infrastructure
- higher uncertainty
- limited model choices

Their motivation may be experimentation and interest in new technology.

Early adopters

Consumers start choosing EVs because they believe EVs represent the future of transportation.

They may also value:

- technology
- environmental considerations
- lower operating costs
- new features

Early majority

Consumers wait until:

- more charging stations are available
- more vehicle models exist
- prices become more competitive
- reliability is demonstrated

Late majority

Consumers switch when EVs become common and increasingly expected.

Laggards

Some continue using conventional vehicles until:

- their existing vehicle needs replacement
 - regulations affect their choices
 - infrastructure makes EV ownership easier
 - traditional alternatives become less attractive
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11. Why Is Rogers' Curve Important for Businesses?

A company should **not use the same marketing strategy for every group**.

For example, suppose a company launches an AI-powered business software platform.

Innovators

Marketing message:

"Experiment with the newest AI technology."

Focus on:

- innovation
- technical capabilities
- experimentation

Early Adopters

Marketing message:

"Use AI to transform your business processes."

Focus on:

- competitive advantage
- strategic opportunities
- innovation

Early Majority

Marketing message:

"Reduce operating costs by 25% using proven AI automation."

Focus on:

- ROI
- case studies
- evidence
- reliability

Late Majority

Marketing message:

"Join thousands of businesses already using AI automation."

Focus on:

- industry acceptance
- peer adoption
- ease of implementation

Laggards

Marketing message:

"Replace your outdated manual process with a simple, supported solution."

Focus on:

- simplicity
- reliability
- support
- risk reduction

12. The Key Difference Between the Five Groups

Group	Approx. %	Main Attitude	Main Question
Innovators	2.5%	Experimental	"What can it do?"
Early Adopters	13.5%	Strategic	"Can it give us an advantage?"
Early Majority	34%	Practical	"Does it work and provide ROI?"

Group	Approx. %	Main Attitude	Main Question
Late Majority	34%	Cautious	"Is everyone using it?"
Laggards	16%	Traditional	"Why should we change?"

13. Easy Classroom Scenario

Imagine **Genetic Computer School** introduces an **AI-powered learning platform**.

Innovators

A few lecturers immediately start experimenting with:

- AI-generated quizzes
- AI feedback
- AI lesson planning
- AI coding assistants

Early Adopters

Some lecturers see strategic value and begin integrating AI into their teaching methodology.

They develop structured AI-supported learning activities.

Early Majority

Other lecturers wait until they see:

"Does it improve student learning?"

"Does it save lecturers' time?"

"Are students satisfied?"

Once evidence and successful examples are available, they adopt it.

Late Majority

Some lecturers adopt it only after:

- most lecturers are already using it
- the school formally integrates it
- training is provided
- AI becomes part of standard teaching practice

Laggards

A small group continues using traditional teaching methods until they are required to use the new system or their existing tools are no longer supported.

14. Important Concept: Adoption Is Not Just About Technology

A common mistake is to think:

Good technology = automatic adoption

That's not necessarily true.

Adoption depends on factors such as:

Technology

- **Cost**
- **Perceived benefits**
- **Risk**
- **Ease of use**
- **Evidence**
- **Social influence**
- **Organisational readiness**
- **Support and training**

= Adoption

Therefore, when introducing a new technology, organisations should ask:

Who are we trying to convince, and what evidence does that group need before adopting the technology?

Simple memory formula

Innovators → Try it

Early Adopters → Champion it

Early Majority → Validate it

Late Majority → Follow it

Laggards → Resist it until necessary

And the most important transition is:

Early Adopters → Chasm → Early Majority

because this is where an innovation needs to move from **interesting and promising** to **proven, reliable and commercially useful**.